

or address the issues later in drivers. Keeping silent doesn't solve the issue, and refusing to acknowledge it is downright dumb. Just how many users will be geeky enough to install a patch for rectifying this issue is left to be seen. We feel ATI is being extremely lazy here.

Features

Two of the HD 4850s we received used a reference ATI cooler. The Palit HD 4850 had a custom cooler, consisting of an attractive heatsink with a large fan plonked in the middle. This card ran at least 18 degrees cooler throughout the testing, which proves how much additional cooling is needed for this card. Please note that designing inadequate or flawed cooling solutions isn't just an ATI issue, their green counterparts are guilty of the same too. The ASUS EAH 4850 TOP was overclocked to 675 MHz, while Palit and GeCube chose to run their cards at the default recommended clock, i.e. 645 MHz. Bear in mind that the Palit card should have a good overclock potential because of the custom cooler. None of these cards came bundled with any games – sad. All came with DVI to HDMI adapters – an HTPCs builders dream come true – if only they didn't get so hot...

Performance

The overclock from ASUS allows its card to sail ahead of the other

HD4850s although the margin is only wide under S.T.A.L.K.E.R. and 3D Mark Vantage; mind you, Crysis does give an extra couple of fps at maximum settings. Even Company Of Heroes benefits from the higher clock speeds by a decent amount. We were interested to see how these cards performed in comparison to their HD4870 siblings, but with a core speed advantage of more than 125 MHz, and ultra speedy GDDR5, the HD4850 cannot match up to its costlier sibling.

When it comes to pricing, ASUS charges a lot for five per cent more performance – its card is a whopping 30 per cent costlier than the Palit HD4850 at Rs 14,400. At Rs 9,950, the Palit is the cheapest HD4850 card available.

ATI Radeon HD3870

When old isn't gold

Once a proud upstart hoping to dethrone the 8800 GTX, the HD 3870 now finds itself languishing at the bottom of an bottomless pit that we know as obsolesce. With a 775 MHz core, 512 MB of GDDR4 memory, and 320 SPs, the HD 3870 just didn't cut the mustard when it came to performance.

Features

Two vendors had 3870s to send us – ASUS and Sapphire. Both of these cards were stock clocked, and both came with identical bundles, except that ASUS gives

away leather PC pouches and a mousepad with every graphics card. Unlike the 4850, no HDMI adapters are included. No game bundles either.

Performance

Needless to say, with identical specifications both these cards performed nearly identically. There's absolutely nothing to choose between them, except that the Sapphire HD3870 512 MB is priced at Rs 7,900. Even this isn't enough to justify a purchase, since the Palit GeForce 9800GT at Rs 8,250 makes a much stronger case for itself.

The Grand Finale

One card caught our attention and continued to hold it throughout the mid-range category test. The ZOTAC 9800 GTX AMP! Edition was the best performer in this category. It's superb price of Rs 10,555 puts it in a price league with cards that offer a fraction of the performance. In fact, just a handful of cards were cheaper, and performed much lower than this one. A unanimous result – both our Best Buy and our Best Performer awards go to this card. That wasn't all – this card impressed us so much that we decided to award it with our Editor's Pick as well. So that's a hat trick for a solution that should really AMP!(lify) your gaming experience. ■

michael.browne@thinkdigit.com

Contact Sheet		Graphics Cards		
Brand	Company	Phone No	Website	Email
Asus	ASUS Technology Pvt. Ltd.	022 - 6766 8800	Media_india@asus.com	http://in.asus.com/
ATI	AMD Far East Ltd	9820643424	amit.jaokar@amd.com	www.amd.com
EVGA	Tirupati Enterprises	09339207519	mail@tirupati.net	www.tirupati.net
GeCube	Tirupati Enterprises		mail@tirupati.net	www.tirupati.net
Gigabyte	Gigabyte Technology India Ltd	022-40633222	sales@gigabyte.in	www.gigabyte.com.tw; www.gigabyte.in
MSI	MSI	011-41758808/09	marketing@msi-in.com	www.msi-india.com
Palit	Tirupati Enterprises	9339207519	mail@tirupati.net	www.tirupati.net
Point Of View	Tirupati Enterprises		mail@tirupati.net	www.tirupati.net
Sapphire	Aditya Infotech	9311282911	Sanjay.gogia@adityagroup.com	adityagroup.com
Sparkle	Abacus Peripherals Pvt. Ltd.	022 - 40914600 / 40914613	megha@abacusperipherals.com	www.abacusperipherals.com
Zotac	ZOTAC International (MCO) Ltd.	011- 46665666	sales@zotac.com	www.zotac.com